

What the state told us about itself

The data received in the RTI audit, by provenance

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Three kinds of data

Every table carries a provenance tag. [A] is a document a public information officer enclosed with a reply to our request. [B] is a public document at a website a reply pointed to instead of supplying the information: the Tamil Nadu State Information Commission’s annual reports (cited by the Agriculture Secretariat, TN-052) and the Central Information Commission’s annual reports (cited by the Directorate of Family Welfare, TN-308). [C] is the same kind of publication sought by us for states without replies; Maharashtra’s reports are downloaded and deferred, and the Karnataka and Telangana commission sites are unreachable from outside India. Type B is analytically the strongest: official, covering every authority whether or not it answered us, and predating our filings.

Table 1: Coverage and parse quality of the commission data [B]

Tamil Nadu SIC, 2015–2023	Per-authority annexure, 21 fields (requests, transfers, replies, rejections by clause, pending, charges, first appeals). 2629 authority-year rows after dropping department totals. Names harmonised across years into 377 authorities, of which 180 appear in all nine years and 233 in seven or more; 68 appear once (renamed, merged, or truncated by the PDF). Row checks: total = opening + received holds for 99.8% of rows; total = replied + transferred + rejected + pending holds for 93.5% (failures are mostly blank pending cells). The 2019–2022 reports print the table rotated, and a few names are truncated.
Central IC, 2020-21 to 2023-24	Annexure 1, one column per public authority; the “UT of Delhi” block holds 190–200 authorities a year. The 2024-25 report is a scanned image and is not parsed.

*For Gaurav Sood. Generated by `reports/report2_received_data/analysis.py` in the `rti-responses` repository. Nothing here conditions on treatment arm.

1 Tamil Nadu, 2015 to 2023 [B]

Table 2: State-level RTI activity as reported by public authorities to the commission

Year	Authorities	Received	Transf. (%)	Replied (%)	Rejected (%)	FA (%)	Charges/req (Rs)
2015	260	384,938	19.7	77.1	2.65	7.4	3.9
2016	254	376,232	17.4	70.3	3.22	6.8	3.1
2017	251	335,906	17.9	78.6	3.64	7.4	4.4
2018	244	315,651	18.2	77.7	3.97	9.4	3.2
2019	263	325,360	19.3	76.2	3.88	9.7	10.6
2020	260	300,078	20.3	76.0	3.17	10.4	10.1
2021	259	499,664	21.2	75.5	2.33	11.0	5.1
2022	277	461,821	23.2	72.9	2.20	10.6	10.6
2023	277	468,587	22.2	75.7	1.83	10.9	3.4

Notes: Sums over authority rows; shares are ratios of sums to requests received. “Replied” is the commission’s “disposed by giving information”. First appeals are those received by first appellate authorities in the year. Charges are copying and other charges collected, excluding the Rs 10 application fee where separately reported. 2021 is the first full year of the online portal, which coincides with the jump in volume.

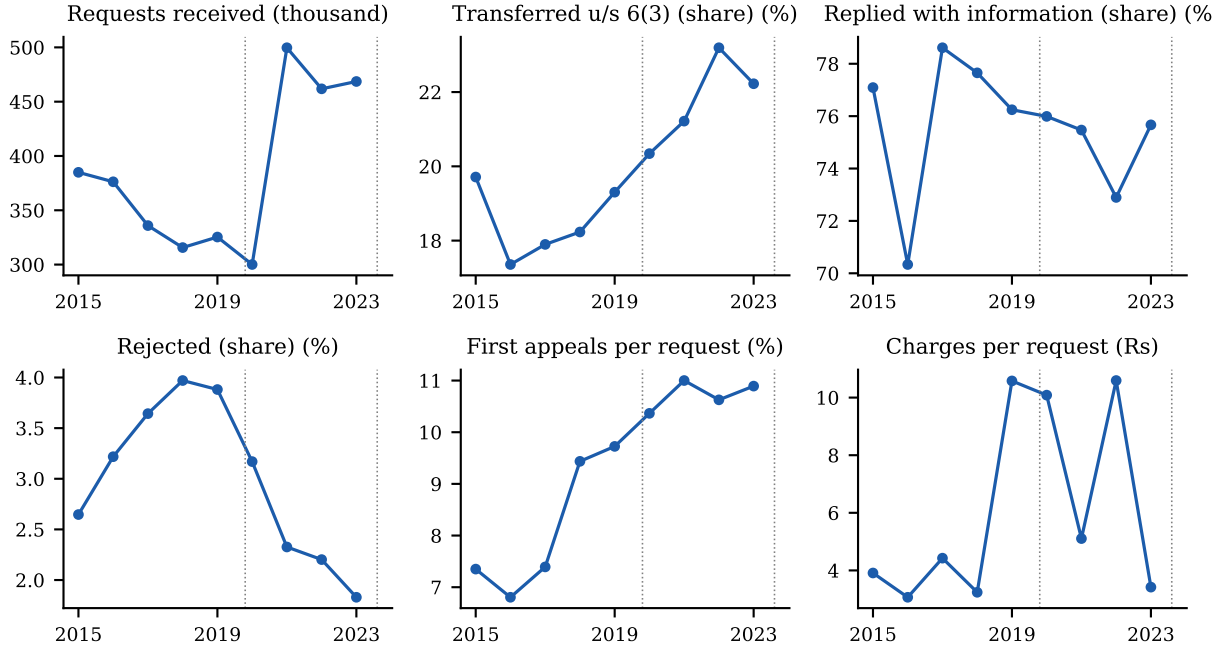


Figure 1: The same series, with the 2019 amendment and the DPDP Act marked

Notes: Annual data; the amendment (October 2019) and COVID (2020) are adjacent, so nothing here separates them.

Table 3: Departments ranked by 2023 volume

Department	Auth.	Received	Share (%)	Transf. (%)	Replied (%)	Rejected (%)	FA (%)
Revenue and Disaster Management Department	6	152,674	32.6	35	64	1.0	10.4
Home Prohibition and Excise Department	13	69,493	14.8	9	87	4.5	10.9
Rural Development and Panchayat Raj Department,	6	40,199	8.6	17	80	0.5	11.7
Commercial Taxes and Registration Department	3	33,034	7.0	11	88	0.3	11.7
Municipal Administration and Water Supply Department	5	23,148	4.9	13	86	0.7	11.8
Higher Education Department	20	20,885	4.5	13	85	1.2	8.0
Health and Family Welfare Department,	15	14,122	3.0	17	84	3.1	8.2
Energy Department	6	12,439	2.7	14	82	2.9	16.4
Tourism, Culture and Religious Endowments Department	7	11,613	2.5	26	63	1.2	15.3
Co-operation, Food and Consumer Protection Department	5	9,625	2.1	36	64	1.2	14.8
Transport Department	13	9,373	2.0	6	94	3.3	16.2
Housing and Urban Development Department	6	9,090	1.9	13	83	0.6	11.3
School Education Department	10	8,547	1.8	30	75	0.4	6.2
Highways and Minor Ports Department	5	7,601	1.6	23	76	1.0	7.6
Public Department	10	6,045	1.3	66	27	7.0	8.3
All departments	284	468,587	100	22	76	1.8	10.9

Notes: Top 15 of 40 departments in 2023. Department assignment follows the report's own grouping. The top 10 percent of authorities (277 in 2023) handle 84 percent of requests (Figure 2).

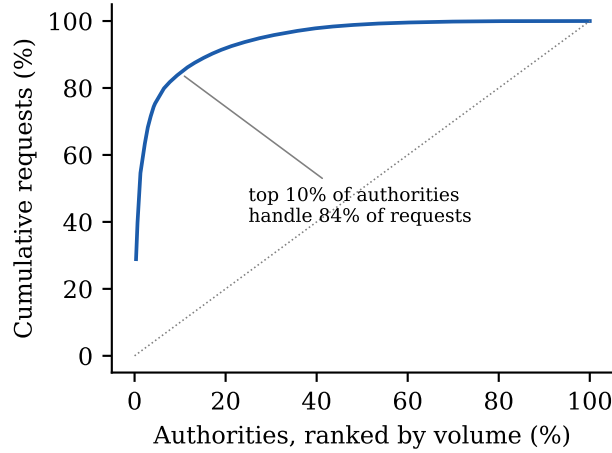
**Figure 2:** Concentration of request volume across authorities, 2023

Table 4: Tier as a routing layer: pooled 2015–2023

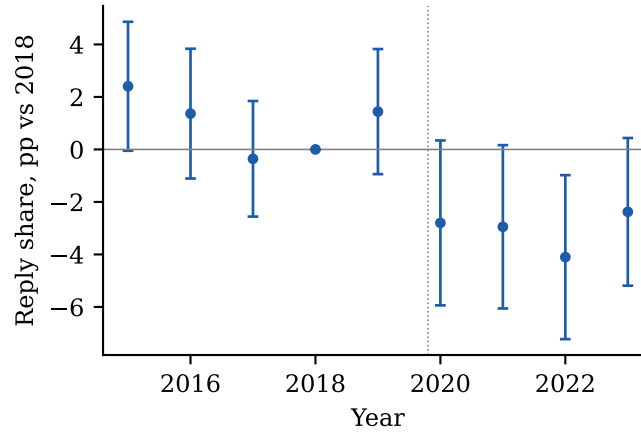
Tier	Auth.	Received/yr	Transf. (%)	Replied (%)	Rejected (%)	Req./PIO	FA (%)
Body/Corporation	136	46,153	7	89	2.9	46	12.2
HOD	219	320,439	20	76	2.7	29	9.1
Secretariat	52	18,767	64	31	5.0	76	7.4

Notes: Tier from the authority’s name: “Secretariat” departments; heads of department (directorates and commissionerates); corporations, boards, commissions, universities and tribunals. A secretariat department routes about two thirds of what it receives under Section 6(3). This is the basis for the proposed PAP amendment that a transfer at the secretariat tier is scored as the compliant response it is.

Table 5: Persistence of authority behaviour: two-way fixed effects, authorities with five or more years

Outcome	Authorities	Rows	Between-authority R^2	Lag-1 autocorr.
log requests received	241	2199	0.90	0.91
reply share	241	2199	0.61	0.64
first appeals per request	241	1909	0.18	0.28

Notes: Specification: $y_{it} = \alpha_i + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{it}$. “Between-authority R^2 ” is the increase in R^2 from adding authority effects to year effects. Lag-1 autocorrelation is the correlation of y_{it} with $y_{i,t-1}$ over consecutive years. Volume is almost entirely an authority characteristic; the reply share is about half persistent; the appeal rate is mostly year-to-year noise. Implication for the audit: request volume is a strong pre-treatment covariate, and an office’s official reply share is a meaningful, if noisy, prior for its behaviour toward us.

**Figure 3:** Year effects on the reply share, 2018 base, authority fixed effects, 95% intervals clustered by authority (241 authorities)

Notes: An event-study reading around the 2019 amendment is confounded by COVID and by the 2021 portal launch; the figure is descriptive.

Table 6: The appeals funnel

Year	Requests	First appeals	FA/req (%)	FA disposed	FA rejected	FA pending	2nd appeals (SIC)	SIC disposed
2015	384,938	28,295	7.4	26,253	1,518	2,037	–	–
2016	376,232	25,603	6.8	24,632	2,208	1,928	–	–
2017	335,906	24,833	7.4	23,433	2,416	1,803	–	–
2018	315,651	29,786	9.4	28,537	1,267	1,531	–	–
2019	325,360	31,643	9.7	29,875	1,364	1,618	–	–
2020	300,078	31,104	10.4	28,539	1,387	2,788	–	–
2021	499,664	54,967	11.0	53,129	1,368	3,482	–	–
2022	461,821	49,077	10.6	45,515	1,772	4,022	–	–
2023	468,587	51,041	10.9	48,638	–	–	21,476	8,369

Notes: First-appeal columns from the authority annexes; second-appeal columns from the body of the 2023 report (21,476 received, 8,369 disposed). The 2023 annexure does not report first appeals rejected or pending. The commission disposes well under half of what it receives in a year, which is the “silent commission” outcome for the appeals estimand.

2 The audit sample in the official record [8]

Table 7: Matching the Tamil Nadu batch’s department and head-of-department offices to commission rows

Tier	Sampled	Matched	Match (%)	Median req./yr	Median replied (%)	Median transf. (%)
Department	40	37	92	432	32	66
Head of Department	136	95	70	77	89	6
All	176	132	75	146	81	14

Notes: Fuzzy matching of office names to harmonised commission authorities, using 2021–2023 means; cutoff 0.75 with manual review pending for unmatched offices. Sub-offices (824 of the 1,000) are not itemised in the annexes; their department aggregate is. The matched file (`data/tn_sample_commission_covariates.csv`) supplies the pre-treatment covariates proposed for the pre-analysis plan: log request volume, transfer share, and official reply share. Unmatched head-of-department offices in the commission list (279 in total) have a median of 92 requests a year.

3 What the replies enclosed [A]

Table 8: One office measured three ways: Co-operation, Food and Consumer Protection Secretariat

Period	Source	Basis	Received	Transferred	Replied	First appeals
2015	Commission annual report (B)	calendar year	556	–	556	31
2016	Commission annual report (B)	calendar year	249	189	58	5
2017	Commission annual report (B)	calendar year	238	196	37	12
2018	Commission annual report (B)	calendar year	247	192	52	15
2019	Commission annual report (B)	calendar year	209	134	208	11
2020	Commission annual report (B)	calendar year	189	128	54	12
2021	Commission annual report (B)	calendar year	382	316	66	17
2022	Commission annual report (B)	calendar year	727	632	87	61
2023	Commission annual report (B)	calendar year	554	503	51	68
2025	Own s.25(2) return enclosed with reply (A)	calendar year	502	430	103	51
Aug 2025–Jul 2026	Register letter in reply (A)	12 months	712	712	–	–

Notes: The register letter counts requests from August 2025 to July 2026; the enclosed return and the commission rows are calendar years. The 2019 row fails the disposal identity (a rotated-table misalignment) and the 2015 row lacks a transfer figure; both are flagged in the parse log. The office’s own return for 2025 (502) sits below its commission-reported 2022 and 2023 figures and well below the 712 it reports for the following twelve months, which is the first case for the register-versus-return cross-check the design promises.

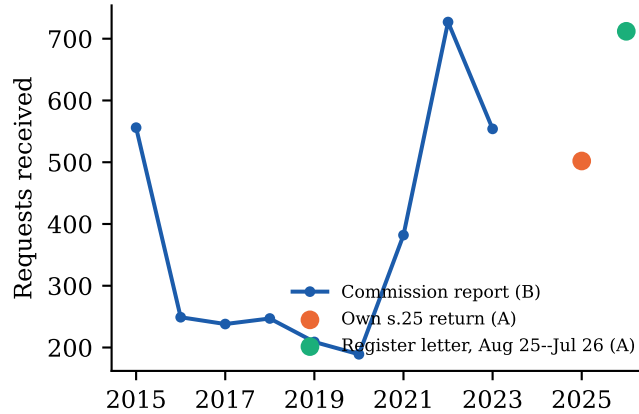


Figure 4: Requests received by the Co-operation Secretariat, by source

Table 9: Section 25(2) Format I return for 2025, enclosed by the Co-operation Secretariat (TN-173)

Public authority	PIOs	Received	Transf. (%)	Replied (%)	Rejected (%)	FA (%)	Rs/req.
Co-operation, Food and Consumer Protection Department, Secretariat	17	502	86	21	0.0	10.2	4.4
Registrar of Co-operative Societies	168	5,902	32	62	2.7	13.3	7.8
Commissioner of Civil Supplies and Consumer Protection	23	667	43	56	0.1	9.7	14.8
Tamil Nadu Civil Supplies Corporation	55	958	4	97	0.3	10.2	10.8
Tamil Nadu Warehousing Corporation	1	7	0	71	0.0	100.0	10.0
State Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission	32	334	5	88	0.0	10.8	5.5
Civil Supplies CID	1	34	6	0	94.1	11.8	0.0
Department total	297	8,404	32	64	2.3	12.5	8.4

Notes: Transcribed from the scanned enclosure. The Civil Supplies CID rejects almost everything under Section 24 (exempt organisation), a lawful blanket exemption. One penalty (Rs 15,000) was imposed against about 8,400 requests. “Rs/request” is application fees plus charges collected per request received.

Table 10: The same authorities in the commission’s 2023 report versus their own 2025 return

Authority	Recd 2023 [B]	Recd 2025 [A]	Replied 2023 (%)	Replied 2025 (%)
Co-operation, Food and Consumer Protection Department, Secretariat	554	502	9	21
Registrar of Co-operative Societies	7,088	5,902	62	62
Commissioner of Civil Supplies and Consumer Protection	594	667	52	56
Tamil Nadu Warehousing Corporation	14	7	100	71
State Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission	321	334	100	88

Table 11: Register extracts and count tables enclosed in replies

ID	Authority	Format	Period	Received	Transf.	Replied	Notes
TN-057	Asst Director of Seed Certification and Organic Certification, Dharmapuri	A+B	2025-08-01 to 2026-07-31	1	0	1	One application (post, individual, service matter), disposed in 11 days; no s.25 return maintained
TN-173	Co-operation, Food and Consumer Protection Department, Secretariat	C	2025-08-01 to 2025-12-31	263	263	–	115 offline + 148 online; all transferred to HODs; register 209 pp
TN-173	Co-operation, Food and Consumer Protection Department, Secretariat	C	2026-01-01 to 2026-07-31	449	449	–	205 offline + 244 online; all transferred to HODs; register 207 pp
TN-052	Agriculture and Farmers Welfare Department, Secretariat	C	2025-08-01 to 2026-07-31	–	–	–	Received/transferred/replied cells illegible in photo; s.7(9) cited; s.25 return referred to tnsic.gov.in
KA-057	Deputy Commissioner of Excise, Ballari	A	2025-08-01 to 2026-07-31	–	–	–	Kannada, handwritten; per-application receipt number, fee (Rs 50 entries) and disposal date; transcription pending
TN-283	Directorate of Sericulture	A (offered)	2025-08-01 to 2026-07-31	–	–	–	66 pp register + 3 pp annual report offered for Rs 138

Notes: Format A is one row per application in the office’s register; B is monthly or category counts; C is period totals.

Entry of the two fee-pending registers (TN-173, 416 pp; TN-283, 69 pp) follows payment. The Kannada register (KA-057) awaits transcription.

4 Delhi benchmark [B]

Table 12: UT of Delhi public authorities in the Central Information Commission’s annexes

Year	Auth.	Received	Transf. (%)	Replied (%)	Rejected (%)	FA (%)	Rs/req.	Penalties (Rs)
2020-21	180	101,647	41.8	0.0	2.5	9.6	4.7	2,264
2021-22	137	76,828	30.4	68.0	1.8	12.0	4.7	0
2022-23	171	124,478	33.0	59.3	1.9	9.1	3.6	1
2023-24	123	76,964	32.0	58.0	3.6	11.5	3.2	0

Notes: Authorities reporting online annual returns under the Delhi block; columns where a year’s layout differs are left as reported and flagged in the parse log. The Delhi filings in the audit (22 drawn, 6 filed) are benchmarked against this block.

Table 13: Largest Delhi authorities by requests, 2023-24

Authority	Received	Transf. (%)	Replied (%)	Rejected (%)	FA (%)
Directorate of Education	28,278	0	76	8.6	8.6
MCD	10,641	100	0	0.0	0.0
Revenue Department	5,137	100	0	0.0	51.5
Office of the Deputy Commissioner North	2,944	12	88	0.0	9.2
South Delhi Municipal Corporation West Zone	2,915	12	85	0.0	8.1
Lt. Governors Secretariat	2,110	49	51	0.0	11.5
Office of the Chief Minister Delhi	1,661	84	11	0.2	12.0
NDMC	1,485	9	59	0.0	27.2
Delhi Transport Corporation	1,229	8	99	0.0	20.2
Office of the Deputy Commissioner West	1,084	17	78	0.1	0.0
Office of the Chief Electoral Officer	1,078	70	35	4.3	11.2
Health and Family Welfare Department	1,069	95	0	0.0	5.8

What this changes in the pre-analysis plan

Three amendments follow. First, tier enters as a routing layer: a Section 6(3) transfer at the secretariat tier is the modal compliant response (two thirds of what secretariats receive) and is scored as such. Second, request volume, transfer share and official reply share from the commission annexes enter as pre-treatment covariates for every matched Tamil Nadu department and head-of-department office; volume is almost entirely an authority fixed effect, so it is the natural heterogeneity dimension. Third, the office-paired misreporting estimator is specified against the official reply share for matched offices, with no selection on response on the official side.